

Live-Commerce Operating Platform Case Study

The Platform Merchants and Creators Ran Their Live-Commerce Business On

One-line judgement: Merchants and creators weren't short of tools — they were short of **one platform**. I built Baidu's live-commerce operating platform **0-to-1** — where a merchant or creator runs their entire live business (products, content, talent-merchant collaboration, marketing, campaigns and data) from one surface. Comparable in functionality to TikTok Shop's merchant and creator platform.

Role & Scope

Role: Lead Product Manager — built the control centre 0-to-1

Product: Baidu's live-commerce operating platform for merchants and creators (a £2M+ daily GMV business) — built 0-to-1.

Scope: Product strategy, workflow consolidation, information architecture, seller/operator research, adoption, cross-functional delivery with engineering, design and operations.

Context

Running a live-commerce business means juggling several jobs at once — account, products, live content, talent-merchant collaboration and marketing. These lived scattered across separate tools, so merchants and creators paid a heavy tax: low operational efficiency, a steep learning curve, and serious gaps where the capabilities they needed simply did not exist yet.

Problem

The problem was concrete:

"Functionality is scattered across separate tools — so running a live-commerce business means low operational efficiency, a steep learning curve, and serious feature gaps."

That scattering and those gaps were a tax every merchant and creator paid. The opportunity was to build the platform that removed both.

Insight

For a B2B operating platform, the win is twofold: **fill the missing capabilities, and bring everything onto the single surface the operator works from all day**. Whether merchants and creators keep coming back is the honest test of whether you achieved that.

Strategic Decisions

- 1. Build the platform 0-to-1, not another standalone tool.** I consolidated the scattered workflows — products, live content, talent-merchant matching, marketing and data — onto one surface, so a merchant or creator sets up, runs and adjusts a live business without leaving it.
- 2. Close the feature gaps, not just tidy the UI.** The old tools were fragmented **and** incomplete; the platform had to add the capabilities merchants and creators actually needed, then bring them together — cutting the learning curve and operational effort at the same time.
- 3. Judge success by whether operators return, not by feature count.** For an operating tool, the honest test is whether it becomes the surface operators run their day from. It collapsed broadcaster onboarding from **72 hours to under a minute** and grew **monthly active merchants +116%**, while materially reducing operational effort per cycle.

Trade-offs

The core trade-off was **consolidation vs. modular simplicity**. Separate, single-purpose tools are simpler to build and ship independently; one unified console is harder to design and to keep coherent as it grows. I chose consolidation because the operator's real problem was fragmentation itself — and a slightly more complex product that ends context-switching beats four simple tools that don't.

Outcomes & Impact

- Consolidated **account, product, content and marketing** workflows into a single seller/operator console.
- Collapsed **broadcaster onboarding from 72 hours to under a minute** — a step-change in how fast the platform could bring sellers live.
- Grew **monthly active merchants +116%** — evidence the console became the surface sellers actually returned to.
- Materially **reduced operational effort per cycle**, lowering the cost of running a live-commerce business on the platform.

What I Learned

- **For B2B operating tools, "one place" can be the whole product.** Removing fragmentation is often worth more than any individual feature.
- **Repeat use is the honest KPI for an operating surface.** Onboarding speed and returning merchants measure whether you actually became part of the operator's day.
- **Consolidation only wins if it also fills the gaps.** Bringing scattered tools together mattered because it cut friction, learning cost and missing features at once — not because it looked tidier.